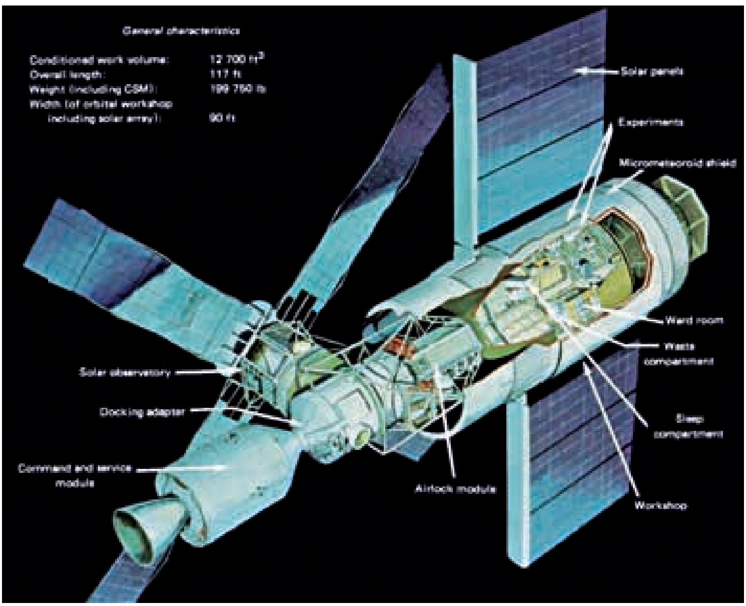
Skylab

While the Soviets were the first to launch the space station with the Salyut programme, reclaiming their pride in the field of space, the Americans weren't far behind. On May 14, 1973, NASA launched a Saturn V rocket carrying its first space station, Skylab. This too would be a monolithic station, constructed in its entirety on the ground before being launched into space. Crew would use the Apollo spacecraft to board it.

Designed for long duration missions, the Skylab programme objectives were twofold: (i) To prove that humans could live and work in space for extended periods, and (ii) to expand our knowledge of solar astronomy well beyond Earth-based observations. Successful in all aspects despite early mechanical difficulties, three three-man crews occupied the Skylab workshop for a total of 171 days, 13 hours. It was the site of nearly 300 scientific and technical experiments: medical experiments on humans' adaptability to zero gravity, solar observations, and detailed Earth resources experiments.

Skylab weighed about 100 tons and had a volume of 283.17 cubic metres. It was separated into two 'floors'; the upper floor contained storage lockers and a large empty space for conducting experiments, and two airlocks, one pointed



A schematic of the Skylab space station